

India's Strategic Autonomy

The Quad, BRICS, Russia, and the World's Most Consequential Non-Alignment

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Executive Summary

India's emergence as a global geopolitical actor in the 2020s represents a significant shift in the Asian balance of power. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India's foreign policy has become more assertive over the past decade, pursuing what analysts describe as "multi-alignment" — engaging with countries in East Asia, the Middle East, and across great power divides to realise its ambitions of becoming a great power CNA[2025-10-06]. Though officially part of the Non-Aligned Movement, India has in practice fashioned a broader coalition of partners and friends CNA[2025-10-06].

India's geopolitical positioning is simultaneously active within the US-led Quad (Quadrilateral Security Dialogue with the US, Japan, Australia); an attendee at the Russia-China-led SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation); a founding member of the expanding BRICS bloc; and a country that continues buying Russian oil while charting an independent course at the UN. This multi-vector posture reflects a strategic calculation that India's interests are best served by maintaining access across geopolitical divides. As former Indian ambassador to the US Arun Kumar Singh observed, countries "attach value to the relationship" with India given "the current international flux" and the options available for deepening partnerships across different areas CNA[2025-12-04].

Part I — The Quad: India's Indo-Pacific Security Architecture

The Quad's Resurrection and Current Status

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue between the US, Japan, Australia, and India was elevated to Leaders' Summit level in March 2021. The first such summit produced concrete cooperation commitments that went beyond the China challenge, with analysts noting the Quad's willingness to "institutionalise networks of partnership" focused on specific issues across the Indo-Pacific CNA[2021-04-06]. The Quad represents a structured mechanism for maritime security cooperation and the projection of a "free and open Indo-Pacific" counter-narrative — though not a formal alliance with mutual defense commitments CNA[2021-03-18].

As of mid-2026, the Quad faces significant uncertainty. Analysts warn the Quad risks "geopolitical insignificance" if summit-level meetings are not resumed, with Trump's disinterest cited as one — but not the only — factor behind the current impasse CNA[2026-05-15]. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio moved to revive the grouping with new Asia projects in May 2026, and Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong acknowledged an obligation to "provide real choices, particularly as strategic circumstances in our region are deteriorating" CNA[2026-05-26]. China's foreign ministry responded that cooperation "should not be directed against any third party" and that Beijing "does not support exclusive cliques or bloc

confrontations" CNA[2026-05-26].

Despite periodic cancellations — a 2023 Quad summit in Australia was called off — analysts assessed that such disruptions were "likely to have little influence on the alliance in the long term" CNA[2023-05-19].

India's Quad Constraints and Strategic Calculus

India's Quad participation has explicit limits that reflect the enduring logic of strategic autonomy. A top US diplomat described Washington as keen to advance India's interests across the Indo-Pacific while explicitly respecting New Delhi's "strong and proud" independent posture CNA[2020-10-13]. India's desire for multipolarity remains even within the Quad framework; as Foreign Minister Jaishankar argued at the June 2022 Bratislava Forum, the Ukraine war demonstrated that India "continues to be a dissatisfied member of the liberal global order despite having made gains through that order" CNA[2022-09-23].

The Indian Ocean Dimension

India has sought to expand its maritime presence in the Indo-Pacific region, including in the Western Pacific, where Indian naval forays and operational exercises have grown incrementally CNA[2023-07-18]. India's political elite recognise that China is a stronger military power with a significant presence in the Western Pacific and the Indian Ocean, and have calibrated India's South China Sea posture accordingly — maintaining a neutral stance on the disputes to preserve balance and India's sphere of influence in the Indian Ocean CNA[2023-07-18].

A strategic complication emerged in June 2024 when China supplied Hangor-class stealth submarines to Pakistan, with analysts assessing China's goal as distracting India in the race for dominance over the Indian Ocean CNA[2024-06-24].

Part II — BRICS: The Non-Western Pole

BRICS Expansion and India's Role

The 2023 BRICS Leaders' Summit in Johannesburg produced the most significant expansion of the bloc since its founding: Iran, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Ethiopia, Argentina, and the UAE were invited to join CNA[2023-08-24]. China views BRICS as "a cornerstone" of its push for a more multipolar global order, and even Xi Jinping's decision to skip the 2025 BRICS summit in Brazil — the first such absence — was assessed by analysts as not signalling a retreat from the grouping CNA[2025-07-02].

More than 20 countries formally applied to join before the Johannesburg expansion, though the proposed expansion caused division among existing members, as the bloc operates by consensus CNA[2023-08-23]. Analysts noted that BRICS members, "especially India and China, have to work closely in order to challenge West's dominance" — a framing India views with ambivalence given its territorial disputes with China CNA[2023-08-23].

BRICS Financial Architecture

An earlier inflection point came in 2014, when BRICS leaders launched a new development bank and a reserve fund — a Contingent Reserve Arrangement with \$100 billion at its disposal — explicitly designed as counterweights to Western-led financial institutions CNA[2014-07-18]. China was expected to make the largest contribution to the reserve arrangement CNA[2014-07-18]. India's position within this architecture is to support BRICS as an economic forum for developing countries while resisting its becoming a Chinese-dominated alternative financial order.

Part III — India-China: The Defining Bilateral

Cautious Diplomatic Engagement

India-China relations reached a meaningful, if limited, inflection point in August 2025 when Prime Minister Modi visited China for the SCO summit in Tianjin — described as "already an important breakthrough in China-India relations" by Fudan University analyst Zhang, though major bilateral breakthroughs were considered unlikely CNA[2025-08-29]. Modi did not stay on to attend China's World War II victory parade in Beijing, a decision that "underscores the delicacy of India's balance" in managing the relationship CNA[2025-08-29].

Hopes were rising in business and civil society for progress on trade, ports, and visa access, but analysts managing expectations noted the structural constraints that limit how far any single visit can advance the relationship CNA[2025-08-29].

The South China Sea and Strategic Balance

India's political elite have calibrated their posture toward the South China Sea carefully. India has sought to maintain neutrality on the disputes, reasoning that if India maintains distance from a space Beijing considers its "strategic backyard," Beijing will in turn respect India's sphere of influence in the Indian Ocean CNA[2023-07-18]. India's growing trade through the Malacca and Singapore Straits gives it direct interest in maritime security without requiring confrontational positions on the South China Sea disputes CNA[2023-07-18].

Part IV — India-Russia: The Oil Paradox

Buying Russian Oil While Maintaining Independence

Russia has supplied arms to India for decades, and following Western sanctions after the Ukraine invasion, India emerged as Russia's top buyer of seaborne oil CNA[2025-12-02]. Russia is now India's largest crude supplier since the start of the Ukraine war CNA[2025-12-04], and Indian government sources confirmed in August 2025 that India will continue to buy Russian oil, citing long-term contracts: "It is not so simple to just stop buying overnight" CNA[2025-08-03].

As of mid-2025, Indian state refiners — including Indian Oil Corp, Hindustan Petroleum Corp, Bharat Petroleum Corp, and Mangalore Refinery Petrochemical Ltd — were pulling back from Russian crude as discounts shrank to their lowest level since 2022, driven by lower Russian exports and steady demand CNA[2025-08-03]. The discount erosion reflects changing market conditions rather than a political decision, and long-term contracts remain in place.

Russia's December 2025 summit visit by President Putin was aimed at boosting energy and defence exports to India, with both sides keen to deepen partnership across different areas CNA[2025-12-02]. Russia has simultaneously sought Indian workers to address domestic labour shortages, with India demanding safety guarantees as a condition of any labour cooperation ahead of Putin-Modi talks CNA[2025-12-04].

India-US Friction Over Russian Oil

Washington has expressed concern about India's continued Russian oil purchases. Trump last month indicated in a Truth Social post that India's purchasing behaviour was a subject of attention, though India government sources indicated the policy would continue regardless CNA[2025-08-03]. More broadly, Indian officials who celebrated Trump's return to power were increasingly describing the American leader as unreliable, and Washington's evolving stance — increasingly viewing Beijing as an "economic rival rather than a strategic one" — worried policymakers in New Delhi for its implications for India's own strategic position CNA[2026-01-20].

Modi's Global Power Ambitions

Modi's July 2024 Russia visit was assessed as "part of a larger push for India to be a global power" CNA[2024-07-12], reflecting a consistent pattern of India's assertive foreign policy under his decade-long tenure that maintains dialogue with all major powers regardless of geopolitical alignment.

Part V — India-Pakistan: The Persistent Flashpoint

Operation Sindoor and Escalation

India-Pakistan tensions escalated sharply in May 2025. India launched missile strikes on Pakistan following rising tensions after an attack in India-administered Kashmir CNA[2025-05-07]. India's defence ministry stated the operation "showed the country's resolve to hold perpetrators accountable" CNA[2025-05-07], while analysts worldwide assessed whether the two nuclear-armed neighbours were "on the cusp of a full-fledged war" CNA[2025-05-07].

The Indian and Pakistani armies have regularly exchanged fire across the Line of Control in Kashmir, but ground troop incursions across the line have been rare CNA[2016-10-07]. India has long accused Pakistan of being too lenient on groups it views as threats to its national security and territorial integrity, a charge Pakistan contests CNA[2024-10-17].

Conclusion: The Architecture of Multi-Alignment

India's foreign policy posture is not neutrality — it is active multi-vector engagement that seeks to extract value from every major relationship while avoiding subordination to any single power CNA[2025-10-06]. The Quad provides a framework for maritime security and technology partnership; BRICS provides Global South legitimacy and a voice in norm-setting for developing countries; Russia provides energy supply and legacy arms maintenance; the US provides technology access and Indo-Pacific alignment.

The defining test of the near term is whether the Quad can regain summit-level momentum under the Trump administration CNA[2026-05-15], whether India-China engagement produces durable de-escalation beyond the cautious reopening of 2025 CNA[2025-08-29], and whether India's multi-alignment strategy proves sustainable as Washington increasingly demands its partners choose sides in the US-China competition CNA[2026-01-20]. India's desire for multipolarity — and its willingness to act on it even at diplomatic cost — has persisted through the Ukraine war and will likely remain the defining feature of its foreign policy CNA[2022-09-23].

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